reached Calcutta on the 28th – addressing barely a word to his disgraced and beleaguered predecessor or his sisters – the news had arrived that Ghazni too had fallen to the Ghilzai, and its garrison, like that of Kabul, had been either captured, slaughtered or enslaved.

By this time, a heavily armed relief force, six regiments strong, with the ominous title of the Army of Retribution had already been despatched from the cantonments of Meerut and Ferozepur with orders to cross the Sutlej and head to Peshawar, ready to wreak revenge. Auckland's first choice of general had been another elderly veteran like Elphinstone, but luckily for the troops the frail and doddering Sir Harry Lumley was ruled out on medical advice. So the command went instead to Major-General George Pollock, who received his orders while smoking his breakfast cheroot on the veranda of his bungalow in Agra. Pollock was a precise, sensible and doggedly efficient Londoner who had been a Company officer in India more than thirty years. A veteran of the Nepal and Burmese Wars, he was, as George Lawrence's younger brother Henry put it, 'as good as any commander that could be sent'. When George Broadfoot heard the news inside the besieged walls of Jalalabad, he also approved. Though no Napoleon, he wrote, Pollock was 'superior to any officer I have yet chanced to meet in these regions'.[7]

At the same time as Pollock received his appointment, orders were sent to Dost Mohammad's keeper, Captain Nicholson, that their prisoner was to be moved from the Afghan frontier and placed in isolation and under surveillance. 'You will be pleased to lose no time on receipt of this letter in adopting the most strict system for the custody of Dost Mohammad Khan,' Nicholson was instructed by George Clerk, the agent for the North West Frontier, 'making him a close prisoner and preventing all communication with him or his retinue by Afghans or Hindoostanis, except with your permission.'[8]

Within a few days, Dost Mohammad had been moved to an isolated property high in the hills beyond Mussoorie. Nicholson's measures to secure his prisoner reveal the extreme fear and paranoia that overtook the British in India at this time. The small sepoy guard was replaced with no fewer than 110 Englishmen from a newly arrived Queen's Regiment. Even Skinner's Horse, one of whose battalions had just been wiped out – along with Skinner's own son James – on the retreat from Kabul, was sent away from the area as 'the proportion of Mohammadans in the Rissalah was so